

I Like Movies

Martin Iver Jacobsen | March, 2025

I LIKE MOVIES. I like dark, gritty movies, such as **No Country for Old Men** and **Låt den rätte komma in**; and I like lighthearted, uplifting movies, such as **School of Rock** and **Paddington 2**. I like movies about love, such as **Before Sunrise** and **About Time**; and I like movies about hate, such as **Relatos Salvajes** and **La Haine**. I like colorful adventures, such as **The Grand Budapest Hotel** and **The Fall**; and I like black-and-white noirs, such as **Rififi** and **The Third Man**. I like animations, such as **Spirited Away** and **The Iron Giant**; and I like documentaries, such as **Ibelin** and **The King of Kong: A Fistful of Quarters**.

I like movie clubs more than nightclubs, and know more good movies than good moves, though I've been known to mix the two up. In my second year of high school, an Italian exchange student joined my class. I had just discovered Italian neorealism and was still under its spell. **Roma città aperta**, **Ladri di biciclette**, **Germania anno zero**. They were almost all I could talk about, but there was, as far as I could tell, not a single girl who shared my enthusiasm or showed the faintest interest in these films. But surely with the new arrival from Italy, I thought, things would have to change. This would be my time to shine. It wasn't. She turned out to be no more interested in Italian neorealism than I was in the classification of fungal subspecies found on the eyelids of midges in Norwegian marshlands. I certainly didn't impress her much, but I probably left a lasting impression.

I watched a lot of old movies in those days. Old movies are movies that came out before I was born. **Roman Holiday**, **En kärlekshistoria**, **Rear Window**, **All the President's Men**. I think of them as time machines. They let me experience a night in Rome in the '50s or a day in Washington in the '70s. There's a kind of permanence to them. In **Rio Bravo**, there's a wonderful scene where John Wayne smiles at Dean Martin, Ricky Nelson, and Walter Brennan as they play a few country songs in his office. Every person in that scene is now dead, and yet their ghosts continue to play together. I had a similar experience watching Audrey Hepburn sing "Moon River" on the fire escape in **Breakfast at Tiffany's**. I was completely taken

by her, almost smitten, though she had taken her last breath before I had breathed my first.

Somewhere in all this, I realized that some of my favorite movies are about people with their hearts in the right place. I use the term “people” in the widest sense possible here, because one of the first films I remember taking to my own heart was **Balto**, which tells the story of a wolfdog of the same name who is shunned by dogs and humans alike for his half-breed heritage. But he’s brave, loyal, and honest; and when all hope seems lost, he’s the one who steps forward and saves the day, and the life of little Rosy, the girl who owns Jenna, the Siberian husky with whom Balto’s secretly in love. I guess I’ve never been one of those people who easily cries at sad moments in movies. What gets me are moments of genuine compassion: Emma saying goodbye to her sons in **Terms of Endearment**, Amanda comforting Brendan in **Only the Brave**, Carl and Ellie’s marriage in **Up**. There’s sadness in all of these scenes, but it’s not the sadness that moves me. It’s seeing good people doing good things.

I read somewhere that when Howard Hawks once was asked what he thought made a good movie, he replied: “That’s easy! A good movie has three good scenes and no bad scenes.” It’s not a scientific formula, but I think it’s a pretty good approximation. This isn’t to suggest that I sit down to watch a movie and tell myself to keep score. No Excel sheets are involved. What I mean is that to see a movie is to discover it, and the initial delight happens when I find myself absorbed in it. I see something like the opening scene in **Inglourious Basterds**, or the closing scene in **The Last of the Mohicans**, or the border scene in **Sicario**, and I realize I’ve forgotten to breathe. Or I see something like the sword fight between Westley and Inigo Montoya in **The Princess Bride**, or Vince yelling “Serpentine, Shell! Serpentine!” to Sheldon in **The In-Laws**, or Mona Lisa Vito explaining the correct ignition timing on a 1955 Bel Air Chevrolet to an arrogant lawyer in **My Cousin Vinny**, and I realize that I’m just having a great time.

I don’t think there’s such a thing as a wrong reason to like a movie. What you like is what you like. There’s nothing to prove beyond reasonable doubt. But I do think there are wrong reasons to dislike one. I’ve heard people say they hate musicals and in the next breath praise **Hamilton**, and when I’ve pointed out this seeming contradiction to them, they usually insist that that’s not the kind of musical they’re talking about. Critics, too, are not immune. **La Strada** wasn’t well received by Italian film critics upon its release because they considered it a betrayal of neorealism. **The Long Goodbye** was similarly dismissed by the critics of the day for not conforming to the noir genre. Both movies broke with expectations, pushed against tradition, and have since become celebrated classics. Moviego-

ers, of course, have every right to dislike these and other films, but the reactions have often struck me more as a kind of closed-mindedness than anything else.

I don't see a movie through your eyes, nor do you see it through mine. That's the reality. To each film we bring our own unique set of opinions, beliefs, and experiences that shape the way we see it. A child doesn't experience Joy in the memory dump in *Inside Out* in the same way as their parent does. Fenster is only one among many in the line-up scene in *The Usual Suspects*, yet for reasons that are entirely our own, it could be him our gaze keeps returning to. Therefore, I don't care much for criticism that treats a film as a code to be cracked or that tells me what *I* should think about it or what *I* should feel about it. The best kind of criticism opens the film up, not shuts it down. It tells me what someone saw, what impact it had on them, and perhaps where I might want to look more closely myself. Roger Ebert's discussion of *Persona*, Every Frame a Painting's video essay on *Drive*, and Very Bad Wizards' podcast episode about *Unforgiven* are some examples of the kind of criticism I'm talking about. They're three different forms of criticism in three different styles, but they all reveal the sensuous surface of the movies they are discussing without mucking around in it. They respect these movies for what they are, because they don't try to replace anything in them with something else.

Of course, this doesn't mean that movies can't be thought-provoking. They can be. *The Great Dictator*, *The Battle of Algiers*, and *Do the Right Thing*, for example, all exist primarily because there were some ideas to which their makers wanted to draw attention. But as Sidney Lumet, among others, has pointed out, content is never detached from style. Form follows function, and ultimately these films fail or succeed not by the weight of their ideas, but by the way those ideas are brought to life. Yes, some movies are able to tell a story and leave me with a feeling and give me an idea. But they made me feel first and think later.

A movie I've thought a lot about recently is *The Swimmer*. I saw it the first time with one of my best friends at the local cinematheque in my hometown. We used to go there every Wednesday to see the movie of the week without ever knowing what the movie would be. We just showed up, watched it, and then went out for a beer to talk about what we had just seen. *The Swimmer* came to us that way. We had never heard of it, and we were both completely mesmerized by it. But that's not really the reason I think about it. I think about it because a lot of time has passed since then. I've grown older, moved to a different part of the country, and I don't get to see him as often as I would like to. But at least I have this memory, of the two of us sitting there in the dark, drinking beer and discovering a

great movie together. And that is, to me, cinema at its very best.

What I've tried to do here is reflect a little bit on this medium and the mysterious pull it has on me, but looking back at what I've written, I see that the mystery has survived the investigation. "Film lovers are sick people," said François Truffaut, and maybe that's the answer, that I have this sickness: I like movies.